the BJP's larger pro-tribal agenda that is expected to benefit the party in the entire tribal belt cutting across Gujarat, Rajasthan, MP, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Odisha.

Arun Sao, meanwhile, gets to become deputy chief minister along with Vijay Sharma, a Brahmin, who was booked for the 2021 communal riots in Kawardha and has won from that seat. With this, the BJP has tried to accommodate the interests of both its OBC and core Hindutva supporters besides, of course, the tribals.

Belonging to a family of farmers, Sai's rise in politics is literally from the ground up, starting from getting elected as a panch in his village in 1989. He did have someone within the family to look up to, though, while setting off on his political journey. His father's elder brother, Narhari Prasad Sai, was a Jana Sangh leader who served as a Union minister of state in the Janata Party government (1977-80). But it was the late Dilip Singh Judeo—a popular political leader among tribals who hailed from the erstwhile royal family of Jashpur and started the ghar wapsi campaign for reconverting Christian tribals to Hinduism—who became Sai's mentor. "I recall the day when a senior leader introduced Vishnu Deo to Dilip Singh Judeo, who immediately took him under his tutelage," recalls Naresh Nande, a lawyer based in Jashpur and Sai's associate for the past four decades.

Having studied in a Jesuit-run school in Kunkuri, Sai, ironically, found himself opposing the Catholic religious order quite a few times after joining politics. Opting for a B.Sc. in college, he dropped out within a year, instead dedicating himself to the Sangh's cause. A year after getting elected as panch, Sai became the sarpanch of Bagiya village unopposed in 1990 and also secured a BJP ticket to contest the MP state election from Tapkara. He won the seat reserved for STs, becoming one of the youngest MLAs in the state at 26, and retained it in 1993. Five years later, he faced his first defeat, but only to be given the Lok Sabha ticket from Raigarh, a seat his uncle once held. He won and held on to the seat for four terms between 1999 and 2019. During Prime Minister Narendra Modi's first term (2014-2019), the by-now seasoned leader was appointed as the Union minister of state for steel, mines, labour & employment. He also helmed the Chhattisgarh BJP twice—once in 2011 and then between 2020 and 2022.

Sai and his wife Kaushalya Devi have three children—two daughters and a son. School friends remember him as someone with an almost calligraphic handwriting. Elaborating on his style of functioning, Nande says, "Vishnu Deo has a soft, affable style. His humility affects everyone around him. Numerous people in Jashpur consider him to be their best friend." Will his 'softness' come in the way of decision-making, though?

Sai's ascent as CM comes at a time when Chhattisgarh faces multiple challenges (see *The Task At Hand*). For one, the BJP has made numerous pre-poll promises, but the financial condition of the state is strained. The Baghel regime presented a budget of Rs 1.2 lakh crore for 2023-24, even as the state faced a debt burden of over Rs 82,000 crore at the beginning of this fiscal. In a state already faring poorly on the development front, especially in tribal areas, fulfilling the promises remains a priority. For, the Lok Sabha election is just a few months away. Corruption remains another irritant, the allegations of which damaged the Congress's prospects considerably in this assembly election. The bureaucracy, which too faced repeated allegations of graft, is an institution that Sai may find difficult to deal with, given his limited experience in the executive.

Many in Chhattisgarh believe the new CM will have the guiding hand of mentor Raman Singh, who has been named Speaker of the assembly. But Sai will have to become his own man pretty soon, if he wants the BJP high command to retain their faith in him. ■

## THE TASK AT HAND

### KEEPING PROMISES

The BJP has made several pre-poll promises, such as Mahtari Vandan scheme, under which women will get Rs 1,000 per month, provision of gas cylinders at Rs 500 and procurement of paddy at Rs 3,100 per quintal. Honouring these commitments will be a fraught task, given the state's strained finances

### MOUNTING DEBT

Chhattisgarh's fiscal deficit stands at 2.99 per cent of the GSDP. The Baghel regime presented a budget of Rs 1.2 lakh crore for 2023-24, even as the state faced a debt burden of over Rs 82,000 crore at the beginning of this fiscal

### DEVELOPMENT IMPERATIVE

The state is rich in natural resources but fares poorly on poverty and health indices. Per capita income stands at about Rs 1.34 lakh, below the national average of Rs 1.7 lakh. The situation is especially worrying in tribal areas

### FIGHTING GRAFT

Corruption allegations proved to be the undoing of the previous Congress regime. Given that a raft of BJP leaders made such accusations, the new CM will have to take these cases—against both politicians and bureaucrats—to their logical conclusion